



119 The Final Conflict



123 Scott Elliot



132 No News Is Good News!

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Touched by Tech

At Sea No More

Entrepreneurs are taking substantial steps towards using technology to help those who till the soil and harvest the sea. The information is there; it needs to be delivered

Prakash Ballakoor

India is—sit back and think about it—a booming economy, an IT hub, a business outsourcing hub, and has an extremely high mobile subscriber growth rate... and is also a country where farmers kill themselves out of monetary debt and poor fishermen mark their graves at sea.

The economist will tell you that waiver of debt or providing subsidies is not the way out for the farmer. The weatherman will tell you that forecasting is not enough to warn the fisherman at sea. So what can be done to help farmers and fishermen, two classes with shared problems? Technology can help: it need not only be for the middle class. It is about supplying the right information at the right time, making the unpredictable more predictable.

It's About Information

If our farmers need to harvest the benefits of a booming economy, they need information: accessible and affordable, timely and customised, usable, searchable, and up-to-date. Large sections of society—mostly rural folk—do not have access to the huge knowledge base built by scientific development. The content is not in the local language, and not deliverable in a form of immediate use to them. For example, a monthly farming magazine cannot report

the likelihood of a pest infestation in the weeks to come.

A Portal To The Rescue

Understanding this need for the exchange of information from and to rural communities, a multi-lingual, multimedia-based agriculture portal called aAQUA (www.aaqua.org) was launched late 2003 by the Developmental Informatics Lab of IIT Bombay in collaboration with the Krishi Vigyan Kendra (KVK) (Agricultural Sciences Outreach Centre) at Baramati (Maharashtra) and Vigyan Ashram at Pabal (Pune district). There are several KVKs across the country.

aAQUA, short for Almost All your Questions Answered, attempts to help the farmer who does not have access to expert advice. Addressed here are farmers' queries based on location, season, weather, and crop, and other such information that farmers or their agents and representatives provide.

How It Works

The farmer (many a time illiterate or semi-literate) puts forth his question regarding his crop or livestock with the help of a local computer operator at an Internet café, commonly referred to as an Internet kiosk, as or through a literate farmer who has an Internet connection at home. There are relevant forums on the portal he can access for this purpose. The portal supports Hindi,

